of whom seventy-two also gave oral evidence—the result of intense questioning by the committee—provides both a panoramic view as well as an in-depth perspective of the Indian mercantile marine.[22]

What was the substance of the evidence provided by the many witnesses?

Both Indian and non-Indian witnesses had little doubt that Indian shipping was in a deplorable state. One informed observer reckoned that less than 12 per cent of coastal trade, and an even smaller 2 per cent of the international trade, was ‘carried in Indian bottoms’. The committee, being an official one, could not of course endorse these figures but was forced to admit that ‘the proportion of the trade on the coast which is carried in ships owned by Indians is comparatively small, while the number of Indian ships which take part in the overseas trade is practically negligible’.[23] Clearly the conditions on India’s coasts had barely improved since the time of SSNCo.

Why was this so? ‘[A] large majority of the witnesses’ affirmed that this was the result of ‘the strong position occupied … by the two or more existing British-owned lines’ which ‘stamp out competition by rate wars, the deferred rebate system and other methods’.[24] The many Indian attempts to cut into the coastal trade had failed ‘due not so much to trade slumps or other fortuitous circumstances’ but to the ruthless British companies. About two dozen shipping companies, ‘aggregating a capital of 10 crores’ had come ‘to grief owing to the opposition of foreign vested interests by means fair and foul’.[25] The sad experience of SSNCo was recalled more than once —by members of the committee as well as by witnesses.

The British companies and their apologists, as could be expected, blamed the failure on ‘Indian inexperience in the shipping trade and mismanagement on the part of the promoters’.[26] They charged that promoters and managers started their enterprise ‘without a good appreciation of the state of affairs’. Once again, SSNCo was cited as example. A few committee members and British witnesses portrayed SSNCo in a negative light. Commander R. Severs, port officer of Cuddalore, mentioned a company running between Tuticorin and Colombo ‘many years ago’ but could not recall why it failed.[27] When Killick Nixon